LECTURE 8: INTERVIEW SKILLS

Introduction

In today's job market, you will likely need to go through some type of interview in order to secure a job. An employment interview is a formal meeting in which both employer and applicant ask questions and exchange information to learn more about each other. This meeting can take place in person, over the telephone, or via video conferencing. The atmosphere may be formal or fairly casual. It may involve just you and the employer, or you and a group of people or panel. Regardless, your interview serves a distinct purpose for both you and your potential employer.

The hiring manager uses the interview to assess your qualifications and determine if you are the best candidate for the job. The job interview is your chance to find out if the company—and the job—are a good match for you.

OBJECTIVE:

Upon successful completion, students will be able to successfully prepare for interviews adequately.

Lecture outline

- What is an interview
- Features of an interview
- Importance of interviews
- Types of interviews
- preparation for successful interviews

What is an interview?

Interview is an important selection technique where there is two-way exchange of information either on one-to-one basis or by an interview panel. The interviewer gets important information from the candidates and can also judge whether or not they can fit into the organisation culture.

Interview is a two-way conversation. It is a personal form of communication between two people. It is a beneficial process for both the interviewer and the interviewee. The interviewer tells the applicant about the job preview and helps the interviewee make his mind about whether or not he wants to take that job. Though conducting interviews is not based on fixed rules, certain guidelines for the interviewer and interviewee can make interview an effective process.

Features of Interview:

The following are some of the features of interview

1. It is face-to-face interaction between interviewer and the interviewee.

2. It has a definite purpose known to both the parties.

3. It is generally based on pre-structured questions to be asked in a defined manner.

Importance of Interview:

Interview serves the following purposes:

1. Interview helps in selecting the candidate most suitable for the job.

2. It provides the candidate information about the organisation and the job for which he applied.

3. Interview helps in knowing details about candidate's personality.

4. It is a method of direct contact between the employer and the candidate. Employer can observe physical characteristics of the candidates. It helps managers to check authenticity of details in the application form.

5. It helps interviewer and the interviewee know each other in detail. Complete information about the company can be given to the candidate and negotiations on salary and other terms can be made.

TYPES OF INTERVIEW

Organizations use various types of interviews to discover your potentials .These interview are of the following types.

- Structured Interview
- Open-ended Interview
- Group Interview
- Stress Interview
- Video Interview
- Situational Interview

Structured Interviews

A Structured Interview is controlled by the interviewer to gather facts. Here the employer controls the interview by asking a series of prepared questions in a set order. Working from a checklist, the interviewer asks candidates each question, staying within an allotted time period. All answers are noted. Although useful in gathering facts, the structured interview is generally regarded as a poor measure of an applicant's personal qualities. Some companies use structured interviews to create uniformity in their hiring process

Open-ended Interviews

Opening-ended interview is less formal and unstructured. In an open-ended interview, the recruiter encourages the candidate to speak freely. The interviewer poses broad, open-ended question and encourages the applicant to talk freely. It is good for bringing out an applicant's personality and is used to test professional judgment. However, some candidates reveal too much, rambling on about personal or family problems that have nothing to do with their qualifications for employment, their ability to get along with coworkers, or any personal interests that could benefit their performance on the job. So be careful. To strike a delicate balance between being friendly, remember that you're in a business situation.

Group Interviews:

This is a type of interview in which recruiters meet several candidates simultaneously. Group interviews help recruiters see how candidate interact. These types of interview are useful for judging interpersonal communication. They tell them how candidates relate to one another. Do they smile? Are they supportive of one another's comments? Do they try to score points at each other's expense?

Stress Interviews

This is Perhaps the most unnerving types of interview. Stress interviews help recruiters see how you handle yourself under pressure. They see how well a candidate handles stressful situations. During a stress interview, you might be asked pointed questions designed to unsettle you. You might be subjected to long periods of silence, criticisms of your appearance, deliberate interruptions, abrupt or even hostile reactions by the interviewer.

Video Interviews

As employers try to cut travel costs, the video interview is becoming more popular. Companies use videoconferencing systems to screen middle-management candidates or to interview new recruits at universities. Experts recommend that candidates prepare a bit differently for a video interview than for an in-person meeting.

The following are some guidelines for video interviews:

- Ask for a preliminary phone conversation to establish rapport with the interviewer.
- Arrive early enough to get used to the equipment and setting.
- During the interview, speak clearly but not more slowly than normal.
- Sit straight.
- Look up but not down.
- Try to show some animation, but not too much (since it will appear blurry to the interviewer).

Situational Interviews

In situational interviews candidates must explain how they would handle a specific set of circumstances. "How would you handle this?" Proponents of this approach claim that interview is about the job, not about a candidate's five-year goals, weaknesses or strengths,

challenging experiences, or greatest accomplishment. So the situational interview is a hands-on, at-work meeting between an employer, who needs a job done, and a worker who must be fully prepared to do the work.

Note: Regardless of the type of interview you may face, a personal interview is vital because your resume can't show whether you're lively and outgoing or subdued and low key, able to take direction or able to take charge. Each job requires a different mix of personality traits. The interview's task is to find out whether you will be effective on the job.

What do Employers Look For in an interview?

Having the right personality traits for the job is important in today's workplace.

Employers look for the people who are self-motivated, enthusiastic, not afraid to make decisions, willing to take risks, intelligent, good communicators, and considerate of others.

1. EQ (emotional quotient).

Current research shows that employees with certain personality traits tend to be more successful at their job. As a result, many employers today seek candidates with a high "emotional intelligence," or EQ (emotional quotient).

People with a high EQ generally possess these desirable attributes: self-awareness, good impulse control, persistence, confidence, self-motivation, and empathy, as well as the ability to persuade, articulate a mission, interpret the mood of a group, and communicate with people in terms they understand.

What's your EQ? • Think clearly and stay focused on the task at hand while under pressure.

• Admit your own mistakes.

• Meeting commitments and keep promises.

• Hold yourself accountable for meeting your goals.

• Seek new ideas for a variety of sources. • Handle multiple demands and changing priorities.
• Make sacrifices to meet an important organizational goal.

• Cut through red tape and bend outdated rules when necessary.

• Seek fresh perspectives, even if that means trying something totally new. • Separate from an expectation of success rather than a fear of failure. • Try to learn how to improve your performance.

• Set challenging goals and take calculated risks to reach them. When it comes down to it, every job has basic qualifications.

Employers first look for two things: evidence that a candidate will fit in with the organization and proof that the person can handle a specific job.

Compatibility

Interviewers try to decide whether a candidate will be compatible with the other people in the organization. Compatibility with the organization is judged on the basis of personal background attitudes, and style. Some interviewers believe that personal background is an indication of how well the candidate will fit in, so they might ask about your interests, hobbies, awareness of world events, and so forth. You can expand your potential along these lines by reading widely, making an effort to meet new people, and participating in discussion groups, seminars, and workshops

STAGES OF AN INTERVIEW

There are four basic components to an initial employment interview. They are:

- Introduction
- Questions by the Interviewer
- Questions by the Interviewee
- Closing

Introduction:

The introduction will be very short, but a very important part of the interview. Good body posture, a firm handshake, and steady eye contact should all be displayed during the introduction. Small talk will be on informal topics of discussion to gauge your spontaneity and personal interests.

Questions by the Interviewer:

Your preparation and practice will pay off during this portion of the interview, which will be the longest part. Most interviewers will ask good, open-ended questions that will let you give information about your background. General answers, such as "I am hard working and motivated," don't mean anything to an interviewer until you tell them why you say that. What past experiences have you had that make you say that about yourself? If you do not understand a question, be sure to ask questions that will help you focus your answer.

Questions by the Interviewee:

Again, this is where your preparation and practice will pay off. Prepare a list of questions for the interviewer ahead of time. Be certain you don't ask questions that were answered in the literature or at the information session the night before. However, it is fine to ask for additional information or interpretation of information. Clarify any aspects of the position through your questions. Just as you want the interviewer to ask you open-ended questions, your questions should be stated in such a way that you will receive helpful information from the interviewer.

Closing:

As with the introduction, the closing will be a small part of the interview, but also a very important part. Before you leave, verify contact information for the interviewer. If you have not received a business card, ask for one. Also, verify the next step in the hiring process. Will they follow up with you or should you follow up with them and how soon? Express your appreciation for the opportunity to interview and leave with a smile and a handshake.

PLANNING FOR A SUCCESSFUL INTERVIEW

Congratulations! You have an interview. Don't be too excited too early. you need to take into account that making it to the interview does not make you clinch the job. You are not the only one qualified for the job; all those being interviewed probably have similar skills and achievements, so you need to show that you are the right match.

For a successful interview, effective preparation is necessary. The best way to prepare for a job interview is to think about the job itself. It's perfectly normal to feel a little anxious before an interview. But good preparation will help you perform well. Be sure to consider any cultural differences when preparing for interviews, and base your approach on what you audience expects.

The following are some tips for effective preparation for a successful interview:

Preparation long before the interview

1. learn about the organization

Today's companies expect serious candidates to demonstrate an understanding of the company's operations, its market, and its strategic and tactical problems. Learning about the organization and the job enable you to show the interviewer just how you will meet the organization's particular needs.

You need to check the company website and look at any company literature (if there is any) to find out as much as you can about the organisation.

2. Think Ahead about Questions

Planning ahead for the interview questions will help you handle them more confidently and intelligently. Moreover, you will want to prepare intelligent questions of your own.

- Remind yourself what you put on your application form/CV.
- prepare a career statement about yourself so you can answer the key question which is often asked. You need to practice talking about yourself by preparing a 'Career Statement'.
- Think of the type of questions you are likely to be asked, and how should you respond?

  eg– 'Why are you applying for this job?'.
    - Can you list two or three things you are good at? Try and list two or three skills and combine them all into a sentence or two?

Here are some more examples of typical interview questions

- Tell me about yourself Why have you applied for this job?
- Why have you applied to this company?
- What evidence can you offer that demonstrates you have the skills we are seeking? Can you give me an example of a problem you have solved?
- Why did you choose your particular degree?
- What are your strengths and weaknesses?
- Where do you see yourself in five years time?
- What do you do in your leisure time?

Note: You do not have to rush an answer – take a second to think about what you are going to say. If you are asked something about which you have no knowledge, be honest and say so. You should also prepare some questions you want to ask the interviewer. This will demonstrate that you are interested in working for them and that you have been actively listening throughout the interview process.

3. Build Your Confidence

Building your confidence helps you make a better impression. The best way to counteract any apprehension (anxiety or fear) is to remove its source. You may feel shy or self-conscious because you think you have some flaws that will prompt others to reject you. Bear in mind, however, that you're much more conscious of your limitations than other people are.

Polish your Interview Style

Confidence helps you walk into an interview, but once you're there, you want to give the interviewer an impression of poise, good manners, and good judgment Staging mock interview with a friend is a good way to hone your style. Nonverbal behaviour has a significant effect on the interviewer's opinion of you.

Plan to Look Good To look like a winner

• Dress conservatively
• Be well groomed
• Smile when appropriate Physical appearance is important because clothing and grooming reveal a candidate's personality and professionalism. When it comes to clothing, the best policy is to dress conservatively. Wear the best-quality businesslike clothes you can, preferably a dark, solid colour.

On the day of the interview

- Take a copy of your application form/CV with you in a folder, a pen and paper and the interview contact number, just in case you are delayed and need to contact them.
- Arrive early: Make sure you arrive in plenty of time, but not too early. Ensure you have enough time to freshen up, calm yourself, perhaps with deep breathing exercises and to take the opportunity to get a 'feel' of the place. Remember your interview starts the moment you enter the building and anyone you speak to may feed back to the interviewer.

- Be pleasant to the receptionist and take time when waiting for your interview to note what is happening around you.
- Turn off your mobile phone by now
- Your interview is not just about the company finding out about you – it is a two-way process as you should also be finding out about what it would be like to work there. When you are called in for your interview take a deep breath and be C A L M. This is it!!

DURING THE INTERVIEW

From the moment you meet, your communication with the interviewer forms part of the decision-making as to whether to recruit you; in fact most decisions are made within the first three minutes! So, you need to be aware of both your verbal and non-verbal communication skills.

The following are some Do's and Don'ts of verbal and non-verbal communication during interviews:

Verbal communication

- Show genuine interest in the position
- Listen and answer the questions asked
- Never argue a point
- If you do not understand or hear a question, ask for it to be repeated
- Do not interrupt

Non-verbal communication

Appearance and mannerisms are VERY important – think of body language and facial expressions

- Put your feet squarely on the floor or cross your legs at the ankle
- Put anything you are carrying on the floor
- Rest your hands in your lap
- Nod your head to show you are listening
- Do not fidget
- Be serious but do not forget to smile

AFTER THE INTERVIEW

- Thank the interviewer for the opportunity
- Remember that the interview does not finish until you have left the building

Here are some more suggestions of possible questions in an interview and how you may approach them.

Extracted from and based on **Eunson (2012, Table 20.3 pages 693 – 695)**

Question	Employer's Rationale behind asking Question	Examples of Suggested Opening Responses
Why do you want this job?	Designed to reveal your motivation and whether you will fit in. An open question designed to get you to open up. In answering such a question it is important that you tray and align your goals with those of the organization.	*I want this job because I really enjoy this type of work and I find it challenging. I think that I could make a valuable contribution here at .....*
Why do you want to leave your current situation?	Designed to ascertain whether you are driven toward such a change by career motivation or a desire to escape a sticky situation. Basically looking to detect whether you might represent a solution or a potential problem.	In answering such a question you should be honest about real problems in a dignified way without any malice. Accentuate the positives if possible. *It's okay there, but I think I have gone as far as I can go. I want some new horizons, and they appear to be here.*
Tell me about yourself.	An opportunity for you to divulge you brand statement, but also an opportunity to shoot yourself in the foot. You answer here needs to be focused on pointing out characteristics about yourself that make you the ideal person for the job. It is NOT a question asking you to reveal your life history and irrelevant personal information so far as the job is concerned.	Keep your answer reasonably short – no more than 2 minutes and focused on aspects about yourself relevant to the job. *I think I am an energetic and resourceful person. I am a bit frustrated in my current position, and I need room to grow. I think that I can get that here, and make a valuable contribution in return.*

Question	Employer's Rationale behind asking Question	Examples of Suggested Opening Responses
What is your greatest weakness?	Concentrate you answer on technical skills that can be easily upgraded and show how you are working on improving in the relevant area. If focusing on an aspect associated with your interpersonal skills choose a minor area, that isn't likely to cause alarm and once again identify steps you have been taking to improve.	*I am not quite up to speed with my Excel skills, but I am starting an online course on that next week.* *On the people side I can be judgmental at times when other people don't share my high standards. I have recently started trying to take steps to be more understanding of what might be motivating and driving others.*
Give me an example where you have taken the initiative on something.	A question designed to see if you are energetic and resourceful, but also to see whether you are a rule bender or breaker & possible loose cannon.	*When I was working on the ..... project I couldn't get a clear decision out of my supervisor, so I worked back late three nights doing research into the relevant area, which I then used to persuade him/her to .....*
How would you compare your interpersonal skills to your technical skills?	This is a choice trap. If you say that one is stronger than the other then you are admitting a flaw. The trick is to give a balanced answer here. If one area is weaker make sure you identify how you are currently working on self-improvement.	*I think that my skills in both areas are at about the same level, both areas are important and play an important role in complimenting one another in a role such this. Realising the importance of both areas I am always striving to improve in both.*
How would you handle a situation in which ..... ?	A technique question. Looking to assess your problem solving skills. Typically such questions will relate to out of the ordinary scenarios that could occur in the job that you are applying for.	*Answer is obviously dependent on the scenario.* It is important to provide a balanced answer that shows both resourcefulness but at the same time takes any standard procedures of relevance into account.

Question	Employer's Rationale behind asking Question	Examples of Suggested Opening Responses
Tell me about a time when you have shown leadership.	A behavioural style question. Provide a concise answer that highlights how you were able to get things done through the use of logic and persuasion [as opposed to force]. Briefly outline the scenario showing how you were able to lead the team or group in question toward a successful outcome.	*Several months back the team that I work in got stuck on a problem with regard to ..... I researched the issue and produced a demo solution, which they all embraced. I then came up with an implementation plan which the team were happy to adopt.*
What do you think your referees would say about you?	A min reader question that might catch some interviewees off guard. The key to answering a question such as this is to remain modestly confident and point out those strengths that you are sure your referees would.	*I don't know exactly what they would say, but I am reasonably confident that they would both agree that I am a conscientious and enthusiastic team player who shows a high level of commitment to seeing through set tasks.*
Do you prefer to work alone or in a group?	Another choice trap question. It is important here that you give an answer that shows that you appreciate the importance of being able to work both in a team and independently as required.	*I am happy working in either way, it all depends on what the situation demands and whether working as part of a team or independently fits best. I enjoy the camaraderie of teamwork but also enjoy the challenge of sinking my teeth into a problem on my own. Successfully achieving a task in both instances provides me with a sense of fulfilment.*
Tell me about a time you failed at something.	The key to answering a question such as this is not to identify anything too damaging and to select an incident from which you can express what it was you learned as a result of the mishap.	*About six months ago, I was under a lot of pressure to deliver on a project by a tight deadline. This resulted in my making a few rushed decisions that were less than optimal. I learned from this that I should have been more assertive in stressing the need for a bit more time or extra help. Faced with a similar situation again I think I would do better.*
How do you handle stress?	Checking to see how you handle pressure and crisis situations. Also checking to see if you have a good approach so far as work life balance is concerned - an important area so far as durability is concerned.	*I try to keep perspective on things, and I always get back to others for a reality check. I push myself when required, but I still try to stay objective.* *I find that my involvement outside of work in ..... and ..... helps me retain perspective and acts as a stress breaker for me.*

Question	Employer's Rationale behind asking Question	Examples of Suggested Opening Responses
Tell me about a time you had a personality conflict with another person.	Another behavioural question. The key here is to try and remain objective in recounting the situation and to reflect on how would act in the situation in hindsight and what you have learned moving forward from the encounter / situation.	*I remember a time working with a colleague on a project, and we always seemed to be disagreeing about technical procedures. All staff did some personality teats a few months later, and the results made me realize that we had different styles and approaches so far as attention to detail was concerned. I still feel that this person was off the mark and unreasonable in some instance, but I now understand better where they were coming from and would be better equipped to handle that now.*
What goals do you want to achieve in the next five years?	This is partly a question to see if you are a planner and partly a question to see if you are a job hopper. In answering this question you should be looking to stress goal alignment and synergy so far as yourself and the firm are concerned.	*I want to move to the next level in my career as a ..... and I am also looking to broaden my knowledge and expertise in this area. As I see it, this company seems to be the best place to do that. I will benefit from being here, and I hope and anticipate that company would also benefit from what I can contribute over time.*
What makes you better than all the other applicants we are talking to?	This question is checking your balance so far as self-confidence and humility / modesty are concerned. This can be quite a challenging question that can spook some interviewees and provide an opportunity for others to reiterate their key selling points as a candidate for the job. The key is to stay calm and answer the question in the context of the job position and flow of the interview to this point.	*I can't answer that – only you can. I applied for this position because I think that I have achieved a fair amount, have good potential and now I am ready to achieve more. I hope the best person is offered the position and I hope that on balance you consider that I am that person.*